

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Bloomberg via Getty Images

The **Trump** administration announced a \$1.8bn fund to compensate people claiming they were wrongly targeted by the Justice Department. The “Anti-Weaponisation Fund”, which could pay out claims to [Donald Trump’s allies](#), was created as part of a settlement in a lawsuit the president had brought against America’s tax agency. The settlement ends the suit, in which he demanded \$10bn in damages from his own government.

A jury in California rejected on technical grounds a lawsuit brought by **Elon Musk**, the world’s richest person, against **OpenAI** and its boss, **Sam Altman**. [Mr Musk](#) alleged that they “stole a charity” by converting [OpenAI](#), to which he donated millions of dollars, from a charitable venture to a for-profit company. The jury said Mr Musk waited too long to bring the case.

Mr Trump said he paused a planned attack on **Iran** at the request of the leaders of Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates, because “serious negotiations are now taking place”. Not for the first time America’s president suggested that [a deal](#) stripping Iran of nuclear weapons was coming—and threatened “a full, large-scale assault” without one. Iran has reportedly shared its revised peace terms.

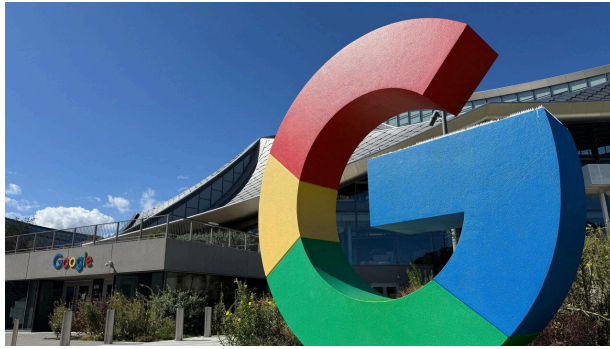
Health authorities in the Democratic Republic of Congo set up overflow treatment centres to take pressure off hospitals dealing with an **Ebola** outbreak. Earlier the World Health Organisation declared the flare-up a “public-health emergency of international concern”. It is suspected to have killed at least 118 people and infected nearly 400 in the regions along the country’s border with Uganda.

Japan’s GDP grew by 2.1% year on year in the first quarter of 2026, well above forecasts, according to preliminary figures. Rising consumption and exports were to thank. But growth will probably slow in the coming quarters as the [fall-out from the war in Iran](#) starts to bite. Industrial production declined in March from the previous month.

America’s Department of Justice dropped fraud charges against **Gautam Adani**, India’s wealthiest tycoon. Mr Adani had consistently denied accusations that his conglomerate paid bribes to Indian officials to win solar-energy contracts, for which he sought backing from American investors. Earlier Adani Enterprises paid \$275m to settle a case relating to Iranian-sanctions busting. Last week the firm settled a separate fraud case with American regulators.

NextEra said it plans to buy **Dominion Energy**, another American utility, in an all-stock deal worth around \$66.8bn. [The AI boom](#) has increased demand on energy companies; Dominion is based in Virginia, where most American [data centres](#) are located. The merger, if approved by regulators, would create America’s biggest utilities company, with a market capitalisation of \$420bn.

Figure of the day: 15%, how much sales rose in the first quarter for GlobalX, an American airline, largely thanks to deportation flights. [Read about](#) the companies profiting from America’s immigration crackdown.



Photograph: Alamy

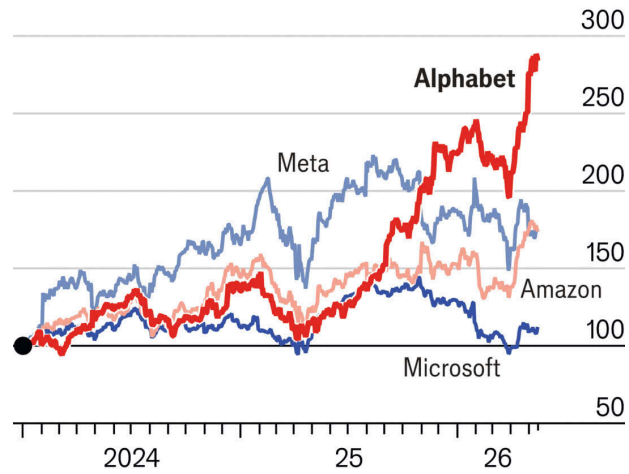
Google provides answers about its AI trajectory

Google will hold its annual developer jamboree on Tuesday. The company will aim to steal the limelight on artificial intelligence back from [Anthropic and OpenAI](#), whose latest models have shown strong capabilities in coding and cybersecurity. Google is expected to unveil improvements to its Gemini models that enable individuals and business customers to build autonomous AI “agents”. These will do more than answer search queries, perhaps including carrying out programming and other tasks on behalf of customers.

Google has other unique strengths in the AI race, too. It makes [its own chips](#), runs its own data centres and builds highly competitive models. It also has a lucrative AI-enhanced digital-advertising business. That gives it surplus cash to invest in AI research, and take advantage of the current intense demand for AI infrastructure. Excitement about Google’s prospects has already seen the share price of Alphabet, its parent company, soar this year.

Artificial advantage

Share prices, January 1st 2024=100



Source: LSEG Workspace



Photograph: Getty Images

Vladimir Putin visits Xi Jinping

Just days after [Donald Trump visited Beijing](#), Russia's leader is making his own trip to the Chinese capital on Tuesday. [Vladimir Putin](#) is set to meet his Chinese counterpart, Xi Jinping, to sign a series of bilateral agreements. The meeting will underline how much Russia relies on China's diplomatic cover and commercial support for its war in Ukraine.

Top of Mr Putin's agenda is finalising a long-awaited deal to build a gas pipeline connecting Siberia to Chinese markets. Russia wants to replace lost European customers. China, meanwhile, may be looking for ways to secure its energy supplies amid disruptions in the Gulf. The visit, so soon after Mr Trump's, will also bolster Mr Xi's foreign-policy credentials at home. State media have already hailed it as evidence of China's emergence "as the focal point of global diplomacy".



Photograph: Getty Images

Africa's Ebola emergency

This week the World Health Organisation declared the spread of the Ebola virus in central Africa to be a “public health emergency of international concern”. So far around 400 cases have been identified in Congo—although this is certainly an undercount—and at least 100 people have died. Cases have been reported in neighbouring Uganda, while Burundi, Rwanda and South Sudan are on high alert.

African countries have vastly improved their response to Ebola outbreaks since 2014, when more than 11,000 people died during an epidemic that lasted two years. But there are still reasons for concern. There is no vaccine for this strain of the virus, and public-health efforts will be further complicated by the weakness of the Congolese state in the conflict-ridden east. [Cuts by America](#) and other donors to international health programmes also mean there is less money to respond. Expect the caseload and death toll to rise further in the coming weeks.



Photograph: Reuters

Chanel is chic again

France's storied luxury *maison* reports its financial results for 2025 on Tuesday. Under its new designer, Matthieu Blazy, Chanel has once more become one of fashion's hottest companies. Shoppers across the globe have clamoured for his latest collections of fringed skirts, puffy bags and two-toned shoes: several models have sold out everywhere. Foot traffic at Chanel boutiques in China was 130% higher during this Lunar New Year shopping weekend in February than the year before.

But Chanel is an outlier in the luxury industry. After a post-pandemic spree, consumers have mostly plumped for [posh resorts and wellness packages](#) over fancy garments. Conflict in the Gulf (a large luxury market) has depressed consumer sentiment worldwide. Even rivals like [Hermès](#), once thought immune from the downturn, have suffered. Chanel will worry that its current popularity is just another fad for luxury-lovers. In the words of the late Karl Lagerfeld, the brand's creative director for three decades: "fashion is ephemeral, dangerous and unfair."



Photograph: Patric Shaw/Shakespeare Theatre Company

Moreland becomes the Moor

Wendell Pierce, best known for playing the dedicated, even-keeled Bunk Moreland in “The Wire” (and the struggling musician Antoine Baptiste in “Treme”), will play Othello in the [Shakespeare Theatre Company](#)’s production of one of the bard’s great tragedies. Their “Othello” opens on Tuesday in Washington, DC and will run for more than five weeks. The cast and crew will be hoping to recreate the success last year of the play’s first staging on Broadway since 1982. With Denzel Washington, an even bigger star than Mr Pierce, it set a record for gross sales (some tickets sold for \$1000).

Like Mr Washington, Mr Pierce started off as a stage actor, and brings a commanding presence to a famously challenging role. He must make the audience believe that Othello, a noble Moor who is a general in Venice’s army, can come to heed the slander of his rival Iago and murder his own blameless wife. Performed well, “Othello” becomes a haunting study of jealousy, hubris and manipulation.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Who along with his then wife Melinda, founded one of the world's largest charitable foundations in 2000?

Monday: Which martial artist from Hong Kong had a Hollywood hit with the film "Rush Hour"?

Education is the passport to the future, for tomorrow belongs to those who prepare for it today.

Malcolm X